PRELUDE VIII

THE *tempo* of this Prelude fixes itself with singular precision within limits that vary only according to the resources of the player's touch. Even after the warning given by the ornaments in bar 2, there is danger of running away downhill in bars 5-8; nor will the player be brought up until he crashes into the delicate florid melody of bars 15-16, which are quite beyond reach of any reasonable *ritardando* from a quick *tempo*. The beginning of the second part, moreover, promptly shows that no obvious *ritardando*, however slight, can possibly effect a compromise; for Bach proceeds to put the two extremes of simple *arpeggio* and ornate melody into juxtaposition. Now, whatever happens, the demisemiquavers must be *cantabile;* there is no sense in any " brilliant " reading of them. And it will be found that they can be given expressively in proportion to the lightness of the touch, so that with the right touch for Chopin's F major Prelude, Berceuse, or *Andante spianato*, this Prelude becomes playable in a *tempo* in which the *arpeggio* formulas preserve an impressively indolent flow which can yield gently when the melody becomes more crowded. Of course, any amount of gradation is required between *pp* and *mp*; and the ear, as well as the fingers, will require training for it, especially when standards have been so constantly set according to the notion that every swell and every high note must amount to a *forte*. (That notion does far more than the absence of the harpsichord octave-strings to make Bach sound thin on the pianoforte.) The turn ~ (which begins to occur in Book II., having hardly yet come into use in Book I.) always contains four notes, not five, and begins, of course, with the upper note. In bar 2 it is best crowded into a narrow space at the beginning of the note, thus: 

The mordents should be deliberate and soft; the ~, on the contrary, as rapid as possible, though very light. (Take three fingers to it )

Phrase broadly. *Legato* throughout will answer very well; but so will any number of varied slurrings, provided they fall into flowing sentences and not into a lesson in grammar.

FUGUE VIII

DURING the first twenty-four bars the Countersubject is as important as the Subject, to which it gives unexpected harmonic turns; and, in the whole Fugue, Episode 1 (which, as often in Bach, occurs before a third voice has entered) is as important as anything in this Æschylean chorus. Accordingly, the student should first get the upper part of bars 5-6 as thoroughly by heart as the Subject and Countersubject. It may, in fact, be simply called the Episode, inasmuch as Episodes 2 and 3 (beyond settling some ordinary cadential matters) recapitulate it bodily.

Donald Francis Tovey: The Well-Tempered Clavier, Book II
Associated Board, 1924. Printed pp. 48-49.
BWV 877. Complete original pages; adjoining commentary is retained.
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Although there are elements of Stretto here, this is a far weightier structure than a Stretto-Fugue. The Episode, as we have seen, intervenes between the two pairs of entries (alto-tenor, bass-soprano) in the Exposition. It also develops itself immediately after the Exposition in the bass in bars 11-12, answered by the tenor in bars 13-14.

Then the Subject enters in the bass, as the first of a series of no less than eight entries, never separated by more than half a bar (at bars 23, 27, and 29), and drawn slightly into Stretto (*i.e.*, overlapping by half a bar) at the fifth and sixth entries (bars 23-27), where the tenor adds the first figure of the Subject, which should be allowed to contribute its quota to the pile. The half-bar breaks only accentuate the continuity of this great development, for all the three breaks are cadences, and in all three it is the rhythmic figure of the Subject which knocks at the door while the cadence is forming. At last a massive close is reached in the dominant; whereupon the Episode sails in again (like the *ritornello* Episode in the first Kyrie of the B minor Mass) and develops on fresh lines (bars $35\frac{1}{2}$-$40\frac{1}{2}$) while the bass rests, leaving the other parts free to float into higher regions in close and light harmony. They descend slowly, and then the bass re-enters (bar 40) with the Subject. The other parts break into massed iambic chords with rests—Bach's supreme type of climax. After the formal full close a Coda is made by giving the Subject simultaneously direct and inverted (the tenor must be very strongly brought out in these last four bars).

These are the essential features of the design. Further details are the semiquaver counterpoint in bars 7-8, alluded to in bars 15-17, and the close imitation of the Countersubject by the bass in bars 22-23. The Countersubject is absent at the entry in bars 17-18, and after bar 23 it is finally crowded out. Clever people are welcome to derive the Episode from bars $1\frac{1}{2}$-2, so long as it is delivered as a thing in itself. The *tempo* is a steady eight or slow four, like the first Kyrie of the B minor Mass. The tone must be cultivated until, without forcing, the player can make it sound really big.